

Chetna Gala Sinha

Chetna Gala Sinha (born 1958, age 68) founded Mann Deshi Foundation and India's first rural women's bank, empowering 1M+ women through financial inclusion.

Education

- Bachelor's degree in Commerce, University of Mumbai.
- Master's degree in Economics and Commerce, University of Mumbai (1982).
- Engaged in political activism during 1970s-80s college years in Mumbai, inspired by Jayaprakash Narayan's land rights movement.

Career

Began as student activist and farmer; married Vijay Sinha (activist-farmer) and relocated to drought-hit Mhaswad, Maharashtra in 1987. Founded Mann Vikas Samajik Sanstha (1992), Mann Deshi Foundation (1996), and Mann Deshi Mahila Sahakari Bank (1997)—India's first RBI-licensed rural women's cooperative bank after overcoming literacy barriers via village classes. Expanded to business schools (2006), community radio, chambers of commerce; serves 1M+ women by 2024.

Awards and Recognition

- Nari Shakti Puraskar – India's highest honor for women's empowerment.
- Jankidevi Bajaj Puraskar (2005) – For rural entrepreneurship.
- Forbes India Leadership Award (2017) – Entrepreneur with Social Impact.

Chetna Gala's Story

In 1987, newlywed Chetna moved to Mhaswad village, shocked to see illiterate women like Kantabai denied bank accounts despite ₹5 daily savings—banks claimed "women can't sign." This sparked her mission: "If they want a bank, let's open one for them." RBI rejected her license citing illiterate promoters; undeterred, she taught 15 women basic literacy in 5 months, secured approval in 1997. From 20 initial savers, grew to 105,000 accounts and ₹780M+ loans disbursed. Balances active farming, raising 3 children, and global travel—motherhood taught her the patience needed for rural transformation.



Leadership at MDF

As Founder-President, Chetna Gala Sinha has architected one of India's most influential grassroots financial inclusion ecosystems through the Mann Deshi Foundation and the Mann Deshi Mahila Bank. Under her leadership, the organization has scaled into a ₹100+ crore asset ecosystem, directly impacting over 791,000 women across rural India. Her approach is deeply embedded in lived realities—designing financial systems not for women, but with women—ensuring accessibility, trust, and long-term sustainability.

A cornerstone of her work is the pioneering of 26 "Udyogini" Business Schools, which have trained over 45,000 rural women across 19 diverse vocations ranging from agriculture and livestock management to tailoring, retail, and digital services. These are not conventional training programs; they are hyper-local, mobile, and context-sensitive institutions that meet women where they are. The results are striking—over 70% of participants have successfully started or expanded their own businesses, with documented income increases of 25–30%, significantly improving household resilience and community-level economic activity.